



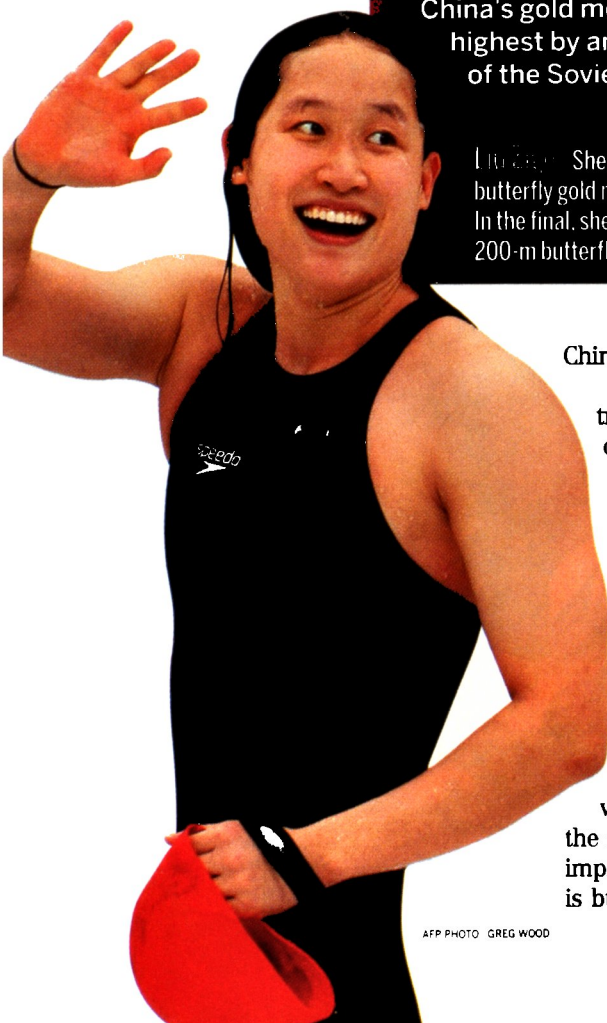
GOLDEN SAGA

The Chinese emergence began with the 2004 Athens Olympics when it finished second with 32 golds

1968	Mexico City	USA	45
1972	Munich	SOVIET UNION	50
1976	Montreal	SOVIET UNION	49
1980	Moscow	SOVIET UNION	80
1984	Los Angeles	USA	83
1988	Seoul	SOVIET UNION	55
1992	Barcelona	SOVIET UNION	45
1996	Atlanta	USA	44
2000	Sydney	USA	38
2004	Athens	USA	36
2008	Beijing	CHINA	51

China's gold medal tally of 51 in 2008 is the highest by any nation since the break-up of the Soviet Union

Liu Zige She won the women's 200-m butterfly gold medal at the Beijing Olympics. In the final, she broke the world record in the 200-m butterfly swimming, clocking in at 2:04.18.



China wants to achieve in sport, it does.

It is why it became the first country since 1936 to break the monopoly of the United States-Russia (and its old Soviet avatar) at the top of the Olympic gold medal tally.

It is how it won 100 medals in 25 different sports. It is how China struck gold in fencing, swimming, sailing, rowing, archery and silver in women's field hockey (in only its third Olympics).

Rechelle Hawkes, three-time Olympic hockey gold medal winner, says, "China has a culture where they try really hard to get to the next level." This drive for constant improvement is what sporting success is built on—with an Olympics to host,

He Ying She represented China in the 2004 Athens Olympics. In the finals of the archery women's team event, China lost to South Korea.



the Chinese state put its weight and focus behind improvement. On all the counts that add in to producing Olympic winners—talent identification, planning, funding and training—China proved to be more determined than any of its rivals to get the formula just right.

There is actually a formula and Indians constantly lamenting about vegetarianism, bad genes and bad karma, know what it is too; the difference between 51 golds and one gold lies merely in the willingness to perfect the formula and execute the plan.

Ever since 2001, when it won the right to stage the 2008 Olympics, China upped its spending on sport with a view to topping the gold medal tally in Beijing. A report in *China Youth Daily*